Chart check: before you believe or share

Good Charts vs Bad Charts · keep this in your binder or phone case

1. READ IT LIKE A REPORTER

Notice: What jumps out first?
Wonder: What questions do I have?
Headline: What story is it telling?

2. CHECK THE CHART

Axis: Do bars start at zero?
Two axes? Stretched to match?
Colors: Do they mean real groups?
Noise: Real trend or random bounce?
Easy? Can I find the answer fast?

3. REAL-LIFE RED FLAGS

Hype words: “exploded,” “skyrocketed”
Tiny print (*): how many asked? who?
Poll “lead”: bigger than the margin?
Short time range: zoom out!
Pictures: grew taller AND wider?
Totals: would “per person” change it?
Pressure: “get in now,” “share fast”

Still not sure? Find the original source and look at the numbers yourself.

⟚ cut along the dashed lines ⟚

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